

Illustration by **SIDDHANT JUMDE**

GLASSHOUSE

TATTLE PATEL?

On June 23, when Nationalist Congress Party leader Praful Patel attended the joint opposition meeting at Nitish Kumar's residence along with Sharad Pawar and Supriya Sule, he tweeted his photographs with RJD leader Lalu Prasad's family and asserted that Opposition parties will unitedly fight against the BJP. A week later, Patel accompanied Ajit Pawar to the Maharashtra Raj Bhawan as the latter took oath as Deputy Chief Minister after shaking hands with the BJP. Bihar mahagathbandhan leaders are now worried that Patel may have revealed everything discussed in Patna to his new-found saffron allies.



Pain Point

West Bengal chief minister **Mamata Banerjee** doesn't repeat her poll tricks. After getting hurt during an emergency landing post her whirlwind campaign for the July 8 panchayat polls, the Opposition questioned the coincidence of the timing and wondered if she'd take to the wheel chair again, like she did prior to the 2021 assembly polls, to attract popular sympathy. However, Mamata decided to reach out to the voters virtually from home. She wasn't on a wheelchair but seemed in pain. Which, the Opposition said, was not so much from the injury as from PM Narendra Modi making public the TMC scam.

PHOTO OOPS!

Assam chief minister **Himanta Biswa Sarma**, it seems, is modelling himself on Prime Minister Narendra Modi, at least in posing for photographs. The PM often releases his solo pictures after inaugurating a big infrastructure project. In the past month, Sarma too has been posing solo after inaugurating a bridge and a flyover and while inspecting an under-construction sports complex in Assam. But he, or rather his PR team, has a lot to learn. Like when they released a photo of Sarma walking alone on a flyover in Nalbari while others, including his cabinet colleague, were seen waiting at the start of the flyover. The photo op looked obviously staged.



Central Aim



His term as the president of the Gujarat BJP may be coming to an end this month, but that isn't slowing down **C.R. Paatil**. Buzz is he is eyeing a central role, which he thinks he deserves after delivering a massive win of 156 out of 182 seats in the assembly election. While a cabinet berth seems unlikely, till the next election at least, a bigger and national role in the party may well be on the cards. Back in Gujarat, power circles are already mulling Paatil's successor.

Raising a Stink

Telangana's Swachh supremacy took a beating as a recent newsreport highlighted how the residents of Sanjay Gandhi Nagar, mostly domestic helps and daily wagers, have to use a nearby hillock to ease themselves. Located right next to the seat of the Telangana government, this has belied the ruling Bharat Rashtra Samithi's claim of the state being fully open-defecation free. Hyderabad MP **Asaduddin Owaisi** has offered his MPLAD funds to build toilets there. Genuine concern or inspired by the coming polls?



CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

Kaushik Deka with Amitabh Srivastava, Jumana Shah, Amarnath K. Menon and Romita Datta